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Review Article

The Celtic Latin tradition of biblical style.

D.R. HOWLETT.

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by John Higgins

The Latin literature of the early medieval period in these islands demands interpretation, explicitly and implicitly. In his *Vita Columbae* (I.40), Adomnan tells the story of St Columba's comment on seeing a sinful priest saying Mass. Columba proclaims, obscurely, '*Munda et immunda pariter nunc permisceri cernuntur.*' The obscurity is too much for his audience, so he continues without a break with an explanation, '*Hoc est: munda sacrae oblationis ministeria per immundum hominem ministrata qui in sua interim conscientia aliquod grande occultat facinus.*' The statement is interpreted.

This passage gives us a pretty direct hint about how to read not only this text, but the entire corpus of literature written in Latin in these islands during the early middle ages. The Celtic Latin writers' concentration on expression and the lush use of figures of speech are the keynotes of their style, despite the fact that they usually deny that they are in fact writing that way. The neat *praeteritio* in the *Vita IV Sanctae Brigidae* asks us specifically not to pay attention to the *positionem vel textum verborum*, and thus calls attention to precisely that. The intention of the authors is to indicate their religious seriousness: as Adomnan puts it (*Vita Columbae, praef. prima*), the reign of God consists

*non in eloquentiae exuberantia
sed in fidei florulentia*

thus showing in elaborate words, exactly how important he actually considers style to be. The two phrases share end rhyme, alliteration/assonance, and grammatical equivalency.

Adomnan's earlier call to his readers that they should '*res magis quam verba perpendant*' is disingenuous, or worse. In his arrangement of words, he exactly contradicts the content of the statement.

The literature is obsessed with the act of speaking and specifically the act of speaking through writing. This is scarcely surprising in a world where much intellectual effort was put into grammatical studies like *Anonymus ad Cuimnannum* and the exegesis of biblical texts, like Aileran's *Interpretatio mystica et moralis progenitorum Jesu Christi*. The writers are as concerned with the authority involved in the act of speech as they are with the content of what is said. Their complex style is a response to the problem inherent in their attitude: how is it possible to speak with authority? And how can we guarantee the validity of what we say?

The elements of style in fact are the elements that validate and give authority to the content of written speech. The style of the literature is such that it demands interpretation; the complex rhetoric and allusiveness make it particularly opaque. The interpretive approach was familiar to all the writers from the contemporary treatment of the Bible: Holy Writ was indeed seen as relevant to their times, but it had to be read right, and the proliferation of biblical commentaries and other scholarship at the time suggests that they would not have been able to read it as a text with a transparent meaning. The writers wrote in the same way that they read: they wrote not to be read so much as to be interpreted. Several levels of reading were familiar and expected. The texts demand that we approach them with several levels in mind, in a way unfamiliar to readers at the beginning of the 21st century. The literature is highly wrought – overwrought perhaps to the modern reader – heavily figured, self referential and self conscious, and playing the intertextual game with the Bible. This literary corpus is the product of a highly literate and almost over-intellectual milieu.

In his new book, *The Celtic Latin tradition of biblical style*, David Howlett has provided us with a hermeneutic technique for the whole range of early medieval Latin literature from these islands and beyond. Derived from the texts themselves, and their clear features, his presentation is most convincing.

Briefly stated, what Howlett calls Biblical Style is the repetition of compositional elements in a literary work in a deliberate and conscious way. At the start of the book, Howlett describes ten rules of Biblical style, all of which have as their basis the restatement of the same idea or of similar ideas in a literary work. These ideas may be simply restated in parallel order, reversed in a chiasmus, or restated in a combination of the two; there may be repetition of similar words in the repetitive elements; repetition of words of similar (though perhaps not identical) etymology in parallel passages, similar grammatical constructions, links through alliteration, assonance and rhyme, and other elements. There are also several 'adjuncts' to the style: arithmetical composition by ratio of the number of words, syllables, or phrases; arithmetical composition based on the placement of words throughout a text; the numerological mystical significance of certain numbers (e.g., 3, 7, 144, 153, etc.); prose rhythm; and the physical layout of a written text on a page, particularly the illumination of certain letters and other decorative features.

Howlett explicitly eschews the interpretation of the content of the texts, treating instead *how* they are written. In this literature, however, the *how* and the *what* are so closely intertwined that they can in fact not be separated. We are therefore presented in these pages with much to do with the meaning of the texts as well. Howlett suggests the revaluation of many of these works as pieces of literature (most notably Asser's *Life of Alfred*, the subject of an extensive and detailed analysis, pp. 273-333) as he already has done with St. Patrick (see n. 1). In addition, though, we get some suggestive glimpses of how the mode of expression affects the thought. Therefore Howlett opens the way to literary criticism of all sorts by critics of every bent, not simply his own discussion of the structural principles inherent in the texts. This by itself makes Howlett's book welcome and more than welcome. There are very few attempts to treat these writings as literature by any scholars. We will now be in a position to submit them to the sort of searching treatment they deserve and which will prove greatly fruitful.

More than just by the way, this book puts Howlett's earlier book on the writings of St Patrick¹ in context. It would have been better if they had appeared in the order in which they were conceived (as Howlett says himself); the problems in the Patrick book would have been far fewer in that case. Briefly, the Patrick book is far too abrupt – Howlett does not take the time there to describe as fully as he needs the principles with which he is working. Here he does better, but still needs to make fuller explanations.

Howlett focuses his attention on one aspect in particular, namely the mathematical analysis of these texts. This is the major new insight which results from his work: that the literature was written, and so must be read, by careful counting of letters, syllables, words, clauses, sentences and paragraphs throughout the works. Parallelism appears not merely as a grammatical or figurative fact but a mathematical one as well. Howlett identifies the origins of the style in the expression of the biblical writers, establishing the existence of a consistent biblical style through analysis of the Hebrew, Pentateuch and Vulgate versions of several chapters from various books of both the Old and New Testaments. He establishes by the use of the three languages that both the Greek translators and Jerome were well aware of what the Hebrew authors were doing and deliberately imitated the technique. Howlett of course has not discovered a new fact of biblical literary form and style – this approach is very familiar to biblical scholars. It would be better if more of their work had been brought explicitly into play in Howlett's discussion to bolster the case. The phenomena do indeed appear in the texts Howlett cites – the solid tradition of biblical scholarship should have been invoked. Howlett terms this technique 'Biblical Style', something of a misnomer, I believe, since what he has identified is a consistent and clearly self-conscious literary tradition of the early middle ages – based to be sure on the Bible, but taught and learned on its own terms in the intellectual milieu of Ireland and Britain. In fact, Howlett provides an account of a specific literary movement,

¹ *The Book of letters of St. Patrick the bishop: Liber epistolarum Sancti Patricii episcopi*. Dublin, 1994. See my review of this work in *Peritia* 10 (1996), 400-7.

style, or tradition in the Celtic countries from the earliest times to at least the arrival of the Normans – for centuries throughout these islands, this technique was clearly taught, learned, and used as a matter of course.

This is a rhetoric, although not a classical rhetoric. What sort of people thought in this way? People for whom literature was rhetoric, rhetoric was grammar, grammar was philosophy and philosophy was the study of number as the basis of reality. Howlett asserts and demonstrates that this literature is composed according to mathematical proportion and ratio. Significant words and ideas are placed deliberately at the precise centre of a paragraph or chapter, or more significantly at the Golden Section, the ratio between two numbers such that the first ('a') relates to the second ('b') as the second relates to the sum of the two ('a + b') so that $a:b :: b:a + b$. This sort of mathematics is not hard, exactly, but rather unfamiliar to literary critics. We are not used to dealing with literary texts in mathematical terms – we use figures of quite another sort in literary criticism!

The discussion of the *Incipit* and *Prologue* to Adomnan's *De locis sanctis* (p. 115) will show how Howlett speaks about these works and will give the reader some flavour of the argument.

The prose of the prologue exhibits rhymes and alliterations and cursus rhythms. It occupies fifty-six words, which divide by extreme and mean ratio at 35 and 21, at Adomnan's reference to writing his book, *craxanda* | *sunt*. There are also thirty-four words from the beginning to *sanctus* inclusive and from *sancta* inclusive to the end.

Together the incipit and prologue comprise seventy words, which divide by extreme and mean ratio at 43 and 27, at Adomnan's reference to himself, *mihi* | *Adomnano*. They divide by one-ninth and eight-ninths at 8 and 62, at the reference to Arculf's dictation, *narratione* | *dictavit*. In these seventy words there are five references to dictating and writing, *craxare*, *craxanda*, *describenti*, *dictavit*, *scribuntur*. The seventy words divide by sesquitercian ratio at 40 and 30. After *craxare* the fortieth word is *craxanda*. From *describenti* to *scribuntur* inclusive there are thirteen words which divide by sesquitercian ratio at 7 and 6. From *describenti* to *dictavit* inclusive there are six words, after which the seventh word is *scribuntur*.

We need some evidence from other sources, which may exist, but is not given here, that the writers had the intellectual and especially the technical facilities to write in this way. Howlett provides us with a chart of Fibonacci numbers which offers a handy guide to finding the Golden Section of a number. He says (p. 17), 'An author who composes a passage containing thirty-four units knows by consulting such a table that the parallel passage should contain either twenty-one or fifty-five units'. This is undoubtedly the case, but where is there any evidence that our authors did ever have access to such a chart? Are any extant, or is there any evidence for their existence? Is there any evidence that the early medieval people had this sort of ability at their fingertips? Finger counting was certainly a highly developed technique in classical antiquity. It would be more than a little interesting to find an ancient or medieval description of finding the Golden Section quickly, easily and accurately without the use of a chart.

Howlett summarises his premise thus (53-4): 'In affirming that modern mathematics has little to do with modern literature one understates the case. But in Antiquity and the Middle Ages men perceived things differently... One may explicate the literary and linguistic arts by the rules of numerical arts...' The remainder of the book is devoted to establishing these phenomena in the primary evidence, the works themselves of the Celtic Latin writers. Any amount of theory from Plato, Cicero, Boethius or biblical texts (all of which Howlett cites in establishing the intellectual background to the Celtic Latin style) will not suffice if the evidence from the texts is unconvincing – but likewise no amount of lack of conviction from doubters will keep us from acknowledging the fact that it appears in the evidence itself. Howlett shows conclusively that the phenomena he describes appear so consistently in these texts that they must be the product of deliberate design.

There are a few places where this is especially convincing – with the letter of Colman to Feradach, for instance (pp. 102-6), which is quite good Latin, but not on the face of it elaborate writing. Still, it refers to writing and literary art, and even though we do not expect high literary style in contemporary

scholarship, it appears here. Colman, in his first paragraph, has arranged his words with concern for various ratios: 1:1, 1:2, and extreme and mean; he has arranged significant words mathematically, and he clearly thinks in the way described by Howlett.

Readers should be aware that the technique admits of some tolerance and approximation in that sometimes one must count words so that the significant intervals are inclusive of the words themselves and sometime not. There is also some variation in the type of ratio involved. The significant intervals can shift and change, even within a single work. We are not stuck with a rigid system. Howlett, in laying out what sort of thing we are to look for, uses the subjunctive a lot. Each one of his list of the ten 'rules of Biblical style' (p. 5 – see above for a summary) includes the word 'may'.

Some readers will perceive this kind of reading as fanciful: any chance relationship can be observed between any couple of words or phrases which are found separated by a significant interval, especially in a literature as charged with significant meaning as that of the Hiberno-Latin writers. Howlett can choose the interpretive method which suits him, and the ratio which serves his purpose. There are many different numbers which possess metaphysical significance, notably 1, 2, 3, 5, 7, 9, 12, and so on. Larger numbers which do not have one of these as a factor are rare enough to be significant themselves. As well, the thought will occur to some that the distinctive features of 'Biblical style' were missed by many perceptive and learned scholars (as Howlett himself notes, p. 392).

Such objections are very wrongheaded. Howlett has identified a pattern of literary creation in which writers do in fact have the ability to choose among several modes of signification. He has established the fact of composition by ratio. The proof of the theory is in the phenomenon itself. The texts do in fact exhibit in a consistent fashion the features that Howlett attributes to them and in far too much profusion to be accidental. The interpretation is neither fanciful nor accidental: the evidence is indisputably there. The comments of modern scholars on the literary value of our texts (Howlett names Walker, Bieler, Tierney, Keynes, Lapidge and Dumville) are

scarcely arguments for considering Howlett's work unreliable. None of their comments have really served as even the beginning of literary criticism of the Latin authors: none of these scholars is primarily a literary critic in any case. Hence Howlett's judgment on modern scholarship:

...there is something fundamentally wrong with the way modern men read... there is something disordered about the way modern men perceive. And if misprision of the merely technical competence of Celtic Latin writers is so deep-seated, there can be no secure basis for the exercise of aesthetic judgments. One needs to understand what an author is trying to do before telling others how well or badly he did it (p. 392).

In learning to read Celtic Latin in the way Howlett proposes, we should be careful to avoid putting ourselves into an interpretive straitjacket. Several points have to be made:

1. Not every ratio or proportion has to be significant. Sometimes things are said in a certain way, because that is the way they are said. Parallel passages or repetitions do not have to carry a load of great significance. This is an important point: even in the midst of elaborate literary structures, a sentence carries a comprehensible meaning of its own.

2. Interpretation of individual passages will vary, and not everybody will (or should) agree with every interpretation put forth in this book. This does not vitiate the technique or the essential rightness of Howlett's perceptions. Just because the central idea is not fanciful, though, that does not mean that an individual interpretation might not be fantasy. To give a few examples: I find the interpretation of two phrases from Cumman on p. 95, referring to the 'similar beginnings' of two succeeding sections – namely '*his perscrutatis*' and '*his perterritus*' – to be strained and insignificant. True, both phrases start with '*his*', but they are not grammatically similar. Moreover, the interpretation is unnecessary: there are many other parallels in this text, and Howlett certainly does not need this one to make his point. In his discussion of *Audite omnes amantes Deum* (*St Sechnall's Hymn*, pp. 138-52), several things bother me – the new readings (for this is a new text) are not justified, they add

little or nothing to the argument, and we are left with no explanation of them. Howlett also tells us (p. 145) that *aequatur* and *apostolis* alliterate in line 4. I cannot hear it. Perhaps in such a literate environment they might be held to, since they start with the letter *a*, but they certainly do not alliterate in sound, which ought to be the main consideration in a hymn (at least notionally to be sung aloud). In his discussion of the hymn *Martine deprecare* (pp. 177-83), he is unclear about what he is doing. Is this a newly edited text? Is it simply a reprint of the text of the MS in TCD? Or what?

These quibbles (for that is what they are) do not affect the interpretation of the passages as a whole, and certainly not the thesis of the book. In fact many – even very many – such quibbles can be made (each reader will doubtless find his or her own, and these are scarcely the only ones I found) and not affect the main point.

3. There might be a danger in assuming that since composition by ratio is a leading feature of the literary technique of the writers, that this is the only thing that is going on. The authors are in fact well able to employ many other literary effects, and do so – and in many cases, the literary structure is more complex than Howlett allows. He states, explicitly, ‘... in these pages there are few expressions of aesthetic judgment, because they would be premature’, and that is certainly true: the judgment of literary criticism will have to take much more into account than this structural technique.

In a book of 400 pages covering such a range of material there are inevitably blemishes and shortcomings.

The Greek cited in the opening chapter, except in one case, does not have accents or breathings. Why on earth not? The equivalent is done for the Hebrew. The one place it does appear correctly is on p. 48 – so it is certainly possible for the publishers to provide correct Greek, but they do not.

Many works of prime importance in Celtic Latin literature are omitted with no explanation. The exception of course is St. Patrick whose works Howlett passes over with explicit reference to his earlier book (see n. 1). The omissions include Adomnan’s *Vita Columbae*, the *Navigatio Sancti Brendani*, the *Hisperica Famina*, and many important Hiberno-Latin hymns. Muirchu

is represented only by his *prefatio*, and Tirechan's *Collectanea* not at all. Some of the omitted texts are dealt with elsewhere by Howlett – we are not informed of this in this book and should have been. Howlett does not let the readers know that his passage on Moucan (pp. 193-213) has already been published², or that his comments on several other works have appeared since he presumably finished the MS of this book. We are left in the dark about his intentions regarding Adomnan's *Vitae Columbae*, arguably the most interesting and complex piece of literature in the entire tradition, which could and should be subjected to this kind of treatment.³

The book should have a bibliography. Howlett identifies the source of this style in biblical literature, and much work has in fact been done in this sort of analysis by biblical scholars – we should be made aware of this. This book is a synthesis of work done in several fields, not all of which habitually talk to each

² 'Orationes Moucani: early Cambro-Latin prayers', *CMCS* 24 (1992), 55-74.

³ Readers should note the following books and articles by David Howlett dealing with the same general topic, gleaned from footnotes to his articles in *Peritia* before 1997 (but not, in general, appearing in his book): *Liber epistularum sancti Patricii episcopi: The Book of letters of Saint Patrick the bishop* (Dublin, 1994); *British books in biblical style* (Dublin, 1997); *Pillars of wisdom in Ireland and England* (Dublin, forthcoming); on Columban na Cummian, see 'The earliest Irish writers at home and abroad', *Peritia* 8 (1994), 1-17; on Mo Sinu Maccu Min's note on the computus, Cummian's *Paschal Letter*, and the *Lorica* of Laidcenn, Cu Chuimne's hymn 'Cantemus in omni die' and the hymn 'Adelphus adelpha meter', see the article 'Five experiments in textual reconstruction and analysis', *Peritia* 9 (1995), 1-50; on the *Versus de anni a principio*, the *Interpretatio Mystica* and the *canon evangeliorum* of Aileran Sapiens, three verse prayers from the *Book of Cerne*, Cummianus Longus, *Anonymus ad Cuimnannum*, Vergilius Maro Grammaticus, the *Oratio Gildae* and the *Lorica* of Laidcenn mac Baith, see 'Seven studies in seventh century texts', *Peritia* 10 (1996), 1-70; 'Two works of Saint Columban', *Mittellateinisches Jhrb* 28 (1994), 27-46; 'The polyphonic colophon to Cormac's psalter', *Peritia* 9 (1995), 81-91; 'Some criteria for editing Abelard', *Archivum Latinitatis Medii Aevi* 51 (1993), 197-202; 'Boethian music in Donnchadh's carmen', *Ériu* 44 (1993), 187-88; 'Rubisca: an edition, translation and commentary', *Peritia* 10 (1996), 71-90; 'Insular Latin writers' rhythms', *Peritia* 11 (1997, forthcoming); 'Charter-confirming clausular rhythms: an essay to honour Pierre Chaplias', *Early Medieval Europe* (forthcoming); 'Aldhelm and Irish learning', *Archivum Latinitatis Medii Aevi* 52 (1994), 37-75; 'Aldhelmi Carmen rhythmicum', *Archivum Latinitatis Medii Aevi* 53 (1995), 119-40; 'A possible date for Aldhelm's "Letter to Heafrith"', *Archivum Latinitatis Medii Aevi* 54 (1996), 99-103; also, 'Insular Latim idama, iduma', *Peritia* 9 (1995), 72-80. I am sure I have missed some things, which is part of the point – Howlett's work in this area is a whole, all of which supports the entire argument. We should have access in an easier way to the complete list of the articles.

other – the history of mathematics and science, medieval studies, palaeography, biblical studies. A bibliography listing works by topic would be extremely helpful to readers unfamiliar with work done in fields not their own.

The index is not what it should be. Instead of an *index biblicus* which is pretty useless (this is not a work of scholarship on the Bible or on the specific use of biblical passage by the Celtic writers, but about the Celtic writers themselves), we really need an index of rhetorical terms, of specific techniques, and of definitions of unfamiliar terms for the uninitiate (who really knows off the top of his head, what a *sesquialter ratio* is?) In his introductory discussion of the origins of the style in classical Greek intellectual life, Howlett includes a passage from the *Timaueus* of Plato with a translation by Jowett. However, the text he uses is the Latin translation of Calcidius which is different in some respects from the original Greek. Presumably, the reason for the use of the Latin is to show that the technique of counting, and the account of the creation of the world by the Creator as an act of numbering and mathematical construction was part of the intellectual background of western Late Antique culture. Fair enough – but we should be warned that the English does not translate the Latin. Better yet, provide a translation of Calcidius.

There is a problem with the cross references. On p. 18, n. 17 directs the reader to p. 401; there are only 400 pages in the book. Read instead 394-5. Similarly, on p. 242, in the footnote, for 'p. 400' read 'p. 394'. This error undoubtedly occurs elsewhere.

Howlett rearranges the texts which he discusses into lines and indented parallel passages, which he marks up typographically to bring out features which he finds significant. One of the things he notes is punctuation marks in boldface, representing features of the manuscript. It is difficult to see 'boldface punctuation marks'. We should instead have no punctuation marks save those in the MSS, if they are that important.

Howlett should sometimes draw a conclusion when he does not. For instance, in discussing Gildas, he mentions that the section he identifies as section 2 (*praefatiuncula* and *descriptio*,

ch. 2 and 3 in the standard numeration) has 261 words, and leaves it at that. So what? Is there a conclusion to be drawn? If so, it should be made explicit. If not, the number is irrelevant. Howlett should be consistent in giving the date and provenance of MSS he cites.

With some reservation about the presentation, this is without doubt the most significant book on Celtic Latin literature to appear in a very long time. Every scholar studying any aspect of the early middle ages in Celtic lands will have to take account of the findings of Howlett: there are implications for the literary, historical and textual criticism of all the sources. This is important enough that reference to this book and to Howlett's other articles and books should be a necessary part of the references given in the new edition of the *Bibliography of Celtic Latin Literature* from the Royal Irish Academy's *Dictionary of medieval Latin from Celtic sources*.

At the end of the book, Howlett proposes a programme of editing and translation on the basis of his discoveries (although, one hopes, not like the translations he provides himself, both here and in his work on St. Patrick). Future editors and translators will absolutely have to take account of this book's findings. Other questions too arise, which will stimulate much interesting research. For instance, Howlett provides an description of a pervasive way of writing. How did the audience experience this literature? Was it primarily experienced as heard, i.e., read aloud by a reader, whether in a monastic context or not? or was it read by individuals, aloud or silently, in privacy? The question is a large one, and of some importance. If the works were, in general, experienced aurally, was the audience expected to recognize the proportions and ratios as they followed the reading? Much scholarship should derive from the points made here – there should be a new valuation of the literary worth of this literature, and the literary history of early medieval Celtic world will have to develop. Howlett opens the way to the discovery of subtle connections in the thought of the early Celtic writers and leads us to a fuller understanding of their intellectual milieu.

There are also benefits to the editors of these texts. Counting the numbers of syllables and the numbers of letters will assist in

recovering the original spelling conventions employed by the author in question and may suggest the provision of emendation, or the retention of otherwise difficult readings. Howlett's comments on the Breton letter to Lovicat and Catihern by the Bishops Licinius, Melanius and Eustochius demonstrate how use of his principles can help editors: 'Recovery of their structural style allows one to correct both the nineteenth century editions and the manuscript itself The word counts show the incorrectness of both editors' deletions and additions of words, which ruin the patterns noted ... without producing other more credible or attractive patterns...' (p. 72). Another example is found on p. 245, in discussion of Cogitosus' *praefatio*, and the reading of *frugifera* and *diffusa*. Howlett proposes the restoration of the correct classical Latin spelling, largely on the basis of their chiasmic parallels. The argument is cogent and illustrates how to use the material in text-critical terms.

The biggest gap in the work is one Howlett deliberately declines to fill. We need a much fuller account of the literary history of this period than we have here. Howlett gives us a series of gnomic statements in the brief discussion of the writers and literary history which brings this book to an end. These few comments are really inadequate as a discussion of the literary history as a whole. What he has done is to have laid the groundwork for literary historical study. He finishes his discussion of the exempla with these words: 'This little survey of fifty writers in a coherent Celtic Latin tradition may suggest various ways in which to enrich understanding of our inherited literary culture by beginning to recover the elements of this tradition'. This book is a beginning, but not by any means the end.

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